The Growing Pains of Transition

The democratisation process in Eastern Europe in the 1990s also represented an opportunity for the restoration of the national sovereignty of the Baltic states, the states of former Yugoslavia, and Slovakia. In fact, regaining independence was sometimes more attractive and emotionally stimulating than the much more demanding task of building a democracy, providing the much needed legitimacy for the painful transition.[88] For painful it was: there were obviously trade-offs between the stakes of market, welfare, democracy and identity, and these trade-offs would, from that moment on, significantly shape the developments of Central Europe.

In the Baltics, the necessary justification for the unpopular reforms was found ‘around the flag of idealised visions of their interwar nations, states, and economic institutions. Conversely, the Soviet legacies were presented as dangerous obstacles to the most important task the reformers set themselves. […] Baltic politicians, therefore, made the most radical break with the past, and paid little attention to the costs involved.’ There was a different approach among the Višegrad countries where the reformers ‘embraced the socialist industrial legacies and qualified workforces as foundations for successful reindustrialisation…’ This was important later on, when the economic crisis hit Europe, and over-reliance on Asian industry proved a burden. A distinct approach could be observed in Slovenia, where ‘politicians were early on challenged by and had to learn to cooperate with a powerful labor movement, which had its own view on what elements of the inheritance ought to survive. Trade unions, center-left politicians, and the reformist bureaucracy backed by businesses that maintained strong links to the state have embraced the legacies of Yugoslav self-management and market socialism, and eventually transformed these into durable institutions of neocorporatist interest mediation.’[89] Such specific economic and political transition has much to do also with the peculiarity of the contemporary rule of law situation in Slovenia, as the next chapter will show. In short, ‘the reliance on nationalism was most prominent in the Baltic states and Croatia. […] even if nationalism has played a role in the Višegrad group and Slovenia, it has not been invoked as